

WEEK 1 OF 4 · Mind

Script 1: The Open Guard**Theme: Observing Thoughts Without Fixation (Mushin)**

Rationale: If we fixate on our opponent's hand, we might miss the kick coming from their foot. This script teaches students to practice an open, non-fixated awareness of the mind.

Ensure students are in their meditation stance. Remind them that if the exercise feels unsafe or triggering, they can open their eyes or stop at any time.

"In the martial arts, if we fixate on our opponent's hand, we might miss the kick coming from their foot. We call this state of open awareness Mushin — or 'no mind.'

Settle into your stance and find your breath. Now, turn your attention to your mind. Imagine your mind is like your dojo or training hall. Thoughts will enter this space — memories, plans, or distractions. Instead of fighting these thoughts or grappling with them, I want you to simply watch them enter the room. (Pause for 15 seconds.)

Imagine you are standing in a neutral guard. You see a thought come in. You acknowledge it. And you let it pass by, just like a sparring partner walking past you on the mat. You don't need to block it. You don't need to strike it. Just notice it.

If you find yourself getting carried away by a thought — perhaps thinking about what you will eat later or a mistake you made earlier — that is okay. You have simply lost your center. Gently, without judgment, bring yourself back to your neutral guard. Back to the present moment. (Pause for 20 seconds.)

Take three more deep breaths, watching the mind with an open guard. When you are ready, gently open your eyes."

MINDFULNESS ON THE MATS